

Home: 785-865-534

Work: 784-864-0739

The Creation of an Internet-Based Learning Network for Mentoring Program Staff & Supporters

Daniel Bassill, Tutor/Mentor Connection, Chicago and Stergios Russos, University of Kansas

Abstract

Local and national attention has been focusing on "mentoring" as a strategy for improving youth academic and social development. While more service programs, schools and organizations are using mentoring as a tool to better serve youth little support exists to help staff effectively initiate, develop, evaluate, sustain and enhance mentoring programs. This proposal intends to expand current work to support and enhance the mentoring infrastructure in Chicago by creating an internet-based network for teaching and learning with staff and supporters of mentor programs. The proposed Mentoring Learning Network is built on our experiences and lessons from organizing conferences for Chicago organizations that provide tutoring and mentoring, conducting a distance education course that involved community participants throughout Kansas, and from evaluation and technical assistance with mentoring-related programs in Chicago and Kansas. This funding opportunity would contribute to piloting the Mentoring Learning Network in Chicago while allowing immediate access to it and eventual expansion nationwide.

- * 1) - Look at Nat Mentoring site - what are we doing diff - discuss
- * 2) - Chicago org focus limits participants - with web we are already internationally focused in idea/knowledge collection
- * 3) - focus on Non School - more need - more mentors -

MATT
Australia
BENTON

The Need for This Project

The national movement to take mentoring "to scale" has been expanding since the late 1980's (cite The Kindness of Strangers). More recently this growth has gained new momentum with initiatives such as America's Promise (www.americaspromise.org/). Generally, mentoring initiatives seek to connect youth with more adults who can guide, tutor, coach or just be a friend in areas where the youth want to excel. This movement is founded on the belief and accumulating research that the greater the number of caring adults youth have in their lives the greater their chances for developing into healthy, happy and productive citizens.

The goal to take mentoring "to scale" has formed out of the realization that mentoring will not result in a societal-level impact if it is not available for all youth. The National Mentoring Partnership (www.mentoring.org/), an advocate for the expansion of mentoring and a resource to mentors and mentoring initiatives nationwide, explains that "there about 13.6 million young people (almost half of all 10- to 17- year-olds in the U.S.) who are considered 'at risk' of failure" (cite How to Be a Great Mentor, Newsweek). National Mentoring Partnership research has identified several barriers to reaching scale that include:

Does the 13.7m refer only to this age group?

1. insufficient support for existing mentoring programs and initiatives
2. not enough mentoring programs in institutions that have the resources to build and sustain them (e.g., schools, communities of faith and corporations)
3. lack of information on the prevalence, performance and progress of mentoring initiatives
4. organizations and institutions are acting on their own, duplicating efforts

T/MC research discovered similar barriers to those discovered by the National Mentoring Partnership. A 1997 survey conducted by T/MC and the Human Capital Research Corporation (HCRC) found that fewer than 6% of the school-age population of Chicago (500,000 students) are enrolled in after-school programs where mentoring/tutoring are part of the program's offerings (Reference X). Programs were not evenly distributed by need, as defined by the number of schools on probation and poverty rates in various areas of the city. T/MC's mapping of organizations that offer tutoring and mentoring (based on an annual T/MC directory begun in 1994) verify the urgency to develop more

lack of opportunities for
Circles to get together to the
Depth needed - inter

programs and enhance existing ^{ones} one in order to respond to neighborhood and school specific needs (see Appendix A).

Further T/MC research indicates a greater need for networking among programs and educational opportunities. In 1994, 55% of 120 organizations surveyed said they had little or no contact with peers, 75% said they would like more contact, and 90% said they would come to a conference for additional training and networking if little or no money was required. Only half of the 272 organizations responding in the 1997 HCRC survey track the number of students served and their characteristics, and far fewer (how many) collect data related to program effectiveness. Also, organizations sought greater understanding the potential impact of volunteers and for the use of computers and program evaluation to increase the efficiency and effectiveness of the programs.

we do not know

These research findings corroborate our lessons from T/MC biannual conferences and participant evaluations. These conferences provide workshops and presentation for program staff and volunteers in areas such as volunteer recruitment and development, program evaluation, and development of community support and collaboration. Presenters are local and national leaders in mentoring and volunteer initiatives. The conferences have been excellent opportunities for networking and exchange of ideas, as attendance has grown to over 260 participants in 1998 (greater than 300% increase since 1994). *Explain with more detail... Participant evaluations suggest improvements in X, Y, Z and requests for additional educational opportunities are endless.*

Over the years, we have learned that staff and supporters are hungry to learn though their resources and Chicago's educational opportunities for them are lean. While many public leaders, celebrities, and media figures provide lip service to mentoring, few communities actually have the leadership and support that gives the day-to-day attention and resources for programs providing mentoring to grow, become self-sustaining, and to last long enough to do the good they are intended to do. A greater number of more relevant, accessible (both financially and geographically), product- and competency-oriented learning opportunities must be made available when and where program staff need them.

The Design of the Mentoring Learning Center

Lead Partner. Since 1994, T/MC has been helping Chicago organizations that including tutoring and mentoring to develop and improve through research, public awareness, resource building, and

training. Also, T/MC has been building and enhancing Chicago's infrastructure to support mentoring programs by developing partnerships and networks among civic and government leaders, the faith community, businesses, school districts, academic institutions, the media and entertainment industry, and other community sectors. T/MC mission is to increase and improve the number of programs and organizations that effectively use mentoring as part of a comprehensive, long-term strategy for moving all youth successfully through school and into productive careers. The T/MC Internet site

(www.tutormentorconnection.org/) offers a sample of the ways and tools available. The Internet site as

well as all T/MC products and efforts represent the collaborative energy of hundreds of local, state and

national partners (Appendix B). T/MC, directed by Daniel Bassill, will lead and distribute project funds,

provide physical space and administration. T/MC will broker participation among organizations

previously participating in T/MC conferences, those identified in the annual directory, and others

nominated by partners and supporters.

YEAS
T/M
YEAS
Adv/works
others identified
via Internet contact

Additional Partners. Stergios Russos conducts research and instructs at the University of Kansas.

Since 1996 he has co-led evaluation and technical assistance of the YouthFriends Initiative.

YouthFriends is an ongoing school-based volunteer initiative with the primary goal of creating an environment in Kansas City where every young person who needs a caring adult in his or her life has one (www.YouthFriends.org). To date YouthFriends exists in 20 school districts and over 200 schools and has included over 40,000 youth and over 5,000 adults.

Mr. Russos also helped develop and implement an Internet-based course, Building Healthy Communities, with compressed-video instruction that engaged up to 90 health and human service agency professionals (including mentoring initiatives) throughout Kansas. The course objectives were to enhance competence among those doing the work of community health and development, promote exchange among those doing and learning about the work, and support and improve the effectiveness of local and statewide initiatives for building healthy communities. Participants, of which only 2 were officially enrolled for university credit, reported that the course increased their interactions with peers throughout the state, energized and improved the professional competence, and generated funding through grants produced during the course (2). Some of the course's learning strategies have been adapted for use in the Mentoring Learning Network. Mr. Russos is also a regular presenter and

workshop leader at the T/MC biannual conferences. Mr. Russos will conduct evaluation and initially coordinate instruction for the Mentoring Learning Network.

Primary Partners (Participants). Though the Mentoring Learning Network will develop a team of educators and assistants to implement the project, the organizations participating in the Network's activities are most truly the primary teachers, learners, developers, and decision-makers as to the Networks shape, maintenance and growth. Participants will include program staff, community leaders, volunteers, business and education partners, and supporters of mentoring. Describe the approximate number of committed participants and their roles, maybe how they will be reached. This May's T/MC conference will be used to test a Internet-based workshop, gain feedback for Network development, recruit potential participants, and gage the Internet access and abilities of potential participants. TRUE

Mentoring Learning Network Objectives

We seek to create an Internet-based Mentoring Learning Network that goes beyond the use of the Internet as an electronic textbook. Our collective work, research, and in particular the biannual conferences indicate that people learn through interaction with others. In this Network as done in the conferences, those participating as "learners" are also "teachers." Most participants are professionals from various fields and with diverse expertise and as an aggregate create a vastly rich learning environment. We aim to re-create this environment experienced at our conferences more often, more systematically, and with greater accessibility for all Chicago organizations. The Network will:

1. Provide useful learning opportunities for what matters most to those seeking to make a difference through mentoring.
2. Increase the number of people who can effectively teach and learn in Internet-based environments.
3. Increase knowledge, competence, exchange, and innovation among participants.
4. Enhance mentoring initiatives' capacity to understand, demonstrate and improve how they are making a difference in the lives of youth, volunteers and their communities.
5. Help sustain existing initiatives and create new ones.

Learning/Teaching Strategies

The Network will be linked to the T/MC Internet site and build on its tools, resources (e.g., publicity, communications). Each learning strategy will be used to develop competencies and related

products in areas such as program development and evaluation, critical thinking, social marketing and recruitment, collaboration, resource development, and program and volunteer maintenance. The Network will make all attempts to keep participation free or at minimal cost to participants. We will apply technology that translates typed and vocal communication in order to allow for participation by those with visual, verbal, auditory, and typing disabilities.

Synchronous Facilitated Workshops will target specific competencies as they apply to a given product. For example, a discussion on 'program development' would be designed so participants would leave with a plan or at minimum a new idea for a program or its implementation. Ideas for discussions will be generated from Network users, staff and supporters. Besides competence development, the key purpose of workshops is to create interaction, networking and collaborative work among participants. Each discussion will have at least one facilitator (depending on the content, purpose and number of participants of the discussion) that will help guide the discussion and ensure fair and useful communication. Initially, facilitators will be Network staff and overtime participants will be trained to be facilitators. Discussions will be planned by staff at regular intervals and also will be self-initiated by users through a technology such as ICQ (<http://www.icq.com/>), WebBoard (<http://webboard.oreilly.com/>), chat room, and forums.

FROM
ANYWHERE

Group
System

Synchronous Interviews will be conducted with local, state and national leaders in the mentoring movement and in related fields. A question and answer period will allow interaction with participants. Interviews will be on specific competencies and products, lessons, recommendations, and aspirations of leadership. Users can nominate leaders to the Network.

Asynchronous Discussions & Interactions will include a managed Listserv for email interaction and exchange for ideas, products, and learning opportunities.

Centers. Network staff will synthesize, distill, and organize information from synchronous and asynchronous activities into the following "centers" (web pages): *Lesson/Products* (lessons and products, ideas shown to work, solutions, and success stories); *Challenges/Problems* (difficult situations, challenges, and problems yet unsolved; a source to generate new discussions and interviews); *Evolution/Pushing New Heights* (ideas, visions, dreams, and aspirations for how the mentoring movement could be more effective, be more than it is); and *New Initiative Development* (information on

the purpose, needs, and resources of newly developing mentoring initiatives so that users can connect and support them as possible).

As whole, the Network's learning strategies are designed to create the type and level of interaction and collaborative work to fully realize its five objectives and remove or attenuate the four barriers noted earlier by the National Mentoring Partnership. Our experiences have taught us that person-to-person interaction related to the production of a common goal, such as obtaining new knowledge or developing a new product, results in improved skills, greater capacity to solve novel problems, reduced duplication of services, increased collaboration on grants and projects, generation of resources, and more effective program outcomes.

Evaluation

Formative, process and outcome evaluation will assess process, intermediate and distal outcomes of participants, Network implementation, and broader community (Chicago and the Internet community) outcomes potentially related to the Network. Qualitative and quantitative data will be collected. Measurement methods will include Internet-based, email, mail and telephone surveys, and direct observation. Appropriate empirical designs will be used to understand differences between participant and non-participant differences (within the 250+ organizations included in the T/MC annual directory), changes over time, and control for threats to internal validity. Initial and ongoing development of the Network will depend on systematic surveying of potential and existing participants to understand how the Network should work to meet the needs that matter most among those working in the mentoring movement.

Evaluation of the Network implementation and development process will include documentation of activities and services provided, use of the Network, and assessment of the Network's ability to serve more participants (eventually outside Chicago), address novel problems, and be a national model for professional education and growth.

Participant evaluation will include: 1) a baseline survey of all new participants (including context/reasons for participating, demographics, history of work related to mentoring and volunteerism, current knowledge/competencies, and goals and expected outcomes); 2) following all synchronous activities, self-reported surveys of satisfaction, knowledge/competence, degree of interaction, products,

take-away lessons, intention for future applications, and recommendations for improvement; 3) quarterly surveys of all participants regarding Network use, satisfaction, application of knowledge/competencies provided by the Network, products, how the Network has influenced their work, take-away lessons, intention for future applications, and recommendations for improvement; and 4) semi-annual focus groups to understand and improve the Network. Synchronous activities will also be monitored for degree and type of interactions and participation and content. Some lessons and insights will be documented as the Network staff synthesize, distill, and organize information from synchronous and asynchronous activities into the "centers" described in the Learning Strategies.

All on line

And At Conference

Mapping the formation of new programs (a process T/MC already uses; Appendix A) will assess the potential broader impact of the Network. New program staff will be contacted to invite their participation in the Network and understand how the Network may have influenced them. Also, all participants will have an opportunity to use an Internet-based monitoring system to document new or modified projects, practices, policies, and collaborations, as well as services, media attention, and generated resources (3; this system is used in the evaluation of YouthFriends and other community development initiatives). Data from these two tools will be shared with the entire Network to help participants understand and improve their efforts.

Evaluation will be used to identify promising practices, redirect efforts for greater utility, and describe means for replicating and adapting the Network for greater dissemination. Our success will be measured by the degree to which we create the conditions for quality mentoring capable of contributing to long-term benefits for youth and their communities.

References

1. Kohm, A. (1998) A Case Study of The Tutor/Mentor Connection of Cabrini Connections: An Effort to Build a Supportive Infrastructure for Tutoring and Mentoring Programs in Chicago. Chapin Hall Center for Children.
2. Russos, S., Fawcett, S. B., Francisco, V. T., Schultz, J. A., Fisher, J., Nagy, G. A. (1998). Building Healthy Communities Through StateWide Distance Education. Paper presented at 126th Annual Meeting of the American Public Health Association, Washington, DC. This paper is currently being prepared for publication.
3. Russos, S., Francisco, V. T., Williams, T. (1998). Evaluating Volunteering Initiatives for Youth: A Community Development Approach. Workshop conducted at the 10th Tutor/Mentor Leadership and Volunteer Training Conference, Chicago.

Appendices

A. Map

B. List of Partners of the web page

Use mapping to see new generation of programs where the need is.

"Product" measures from product/lessons center.: use eval system of community change now using in YouthFriends

Idea generation as measured from products, lessons, expansion.

Bi-annual random surveys for knowledge, core competencies, and application of lessons: who now evaluates their project, who is using our recruitment tools. how has use helped lower operating costs.

Measures of networking and exchange across users and across leadership/users

Measures of development of new programs and expansion/strengthening of existing ones.

Anticipated Challenges and Potential Solutions

Lack technology access -

Lack technology skills -

Fellowships, scholarships

Tech Team

The Learning System's Collaborating Partners

[Dan, let's discuss this section by phone. I'd love to take the lead on this but I want to make sure this will be useful to you given that I do not live in Chicago (wow the real test of distance, internet based work) and I want to position it in such a way that I can still do some of the evaluation. I'm not sure how much this grant want "outside" evaluators who would not benefit from the program's success. We could work it out where I lead both, but not conduct the evaluation directly.]

["Your narrative should offer reviewers a clear description of the roles to be played by each of the partners, who will do what, when, and where, to what ends, and with what anticipated results. Your strategies should be carefully designed to address the central causes of the problem you are addressing, based on your own research and experience, and based on previous experiments by others. Scatter-shot approaches to vaguely-defined problems make poor prospects for funding. The project's goals and objectives should be clearly identified and measurable."]

[Dan, who are some local leaders from groups that you work with, both mentoring initiatives and other who would be useful to sign on as secondary partners?]

Lead agency, T/MC with Steve Russos as project director (independently

connected or directly connected). While this is consistent with what we've been developing, it goes to much greater depth, faster than we have the current capacity to manage. This proposal must bring the infrastructure support to manage this growth, and I'd need to be able to count on you to bear the operational needs on your shoulders while I continue to manage the T/MC (and Cabrini Connections) around it.

It would be great to connect with another local academic partner who might help develop learning modules, etc.

Local volunteer organizations

Business partners

State/National partners

Others we seek financial, human & in-kind support.

Mott Foundation/21st Century Learning. They host a discussion group centered around the 21st century grants.

DePaul - Scott
Chapman Hall - Amelia

Steve, I think you'd be in a better position than I to engage local and national partners to the effort. You are better at building a team. I'm out front leading the team (and recruiting new members).

(others we seek financial, human, and in-kind support)

1) Technology partners - we need to offer a carrot and stick to potential program partners. If we could put a computer, and 10 hrs/week in staff dollars to operate it, into a couple of dozen sites around Chicago, we could probably "buy" some partnership, and provide the tools for them to get into the conversation at the same time.

2) Business and trade associations. Our target for this on-line system is not just non-profits, it is the business community. These are the people looking for schools to produce better-prepared workers and for government to reduce the high cost of poverty and violence.

Include tertiary partners who we will connect with to avoid duplication of efforts, America's

Promise, NMP, National Mentor Foundation,....

Unique Contributions and Potential Implications

However, our ability to turn their needs into curriculum, using their volunteers, technology, ideas and leadership, will enable tutor/mentor programs to better

prepare students to fill these needs. As we demonstrate an effectiveness in this area we should be able to draw on-going flows of revenue from these industries to support our work.

Summary

While we pitch the development of this system to the government, our goal is to have a greater and greater proportion funded by private industry, with their technology, human capital and facilities integrated into the fabric of a constantly growing and improving network of tutor/mentor programs operating and expanding throughout America and moving more and more at risk children from schools to careers, one day, one week, one month and one year at a time.

Budget -- i have not the foggiest idea

References

Support Material